Compliance by Atomization:

The New Equilibrium of Surveillance and Fragmentation

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Abstract

In every previous era, grievance could organize. Workers could strike. Peasants could march. Citizens could read a common newspaper and share a common anger. The mechanisms of organization were physical, local, and visible. Today, grievance is atomized. Each of us sits with our own feed, our own grievances, our own outrage. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics that cannot coordinate. This paper argues that this is not a conspiracy but a structural feature of the new organization, and that it produces a new equilibrium: *compliance by atomization*—a regime with low legitimacy and low conflict, sustained by surveillance and fragmentation rather than belief. The paper formalizes the atomization mechanism, derives the conditions under which the equilibrium is stable, and shows that its stability is real but thin. When a shock comes—a fiscal crisis, a legitimacy event, a new technology that defeats surveillance—the stored grievance releases suddenly, and the collapse is unexpected.

Keywords: atomization, surveillance, fragmentation, grievance, compliance, legitimacy, algorithmic curation, sudden collapse

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1 The Second Great Asymmetry

The ledger framework identifies a first great asymmetry: the ratio of capital's exit cost to labor's. Capital can leave a country in a millisecond; labor cannot. This asymmetry is the structural precondition of every modern extraction.

There is a second great asymmetry, and it is subtler. In every previous era, grievance could organize. Workers could strike. Peasants could march. Citizens could read a common newspaper and share a common anger. The mechanisms of organization were physical, local, and visible.

Today, grievance is atomized. Each of us sits with our own feed, our own grievances, our own outrage. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics that cannot coordinate. We are more informed than any previous generation, and less capable of acting together than any previous generation.

This is not a conspiracy. It is a structural feature of the new organization. The platforms that connect us also divide us, because division is more profitable than solidarity.

2 The Atomization Mechanism

Definition 2.1 (Atomization)**.** *Atomization is the process by which individuals are isolated from one another, preventing shared grievances from coalescing into collective claims. Precarity, surveillance, spatial segregation, and the fragmentation of labor all drive atomization.*

A system can be deeply unjust whilst appearing apolitical if people believe "it's just me" rather than "it's all of us." Atomization is often more effective than outright censorship at suppressing politics.

The atomization mechanism has four components.

First, the fragmentation of attention. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics. Each of us sees a different feed, a different set of grievances, a different set of enemies. The common newspaper, which once produced a common anger, has been replaced by a million private feeds.

Second, the individualization of grievance. Precarity, gig work, and the decline of stable employment individualize what would once have been class-wide grievances. The worker who is exploited is told that the exploitation is their own failure—a failure of skill, of effort, of hustle. What would be a class-wide claim is internalized as individual failure.

Third, the surveillance of organization. The same platforms that fragment attention also surveil it. Every attempt to organize is visible to the platform, and the platform can suppress it. The cost of organizing rises, and the benefit falls.

Fourth, the atomization of the self. The individual who is fragmented, individualized, and surveilled becomes atomized in the deepest sense: they lose the capacity to see themselves as part of a collective. The "we" that is the precondition of collective action dissolves into a million "I"s.

3 Compliance by Atomization

Proposition 3.1 (Compliance by Atomization)**.** *When grievance cannot aggregate, a regime can maintain compliance without legitimacy. The regime does not need the population to believe in it; it needs only to prevent the population from organizing against it. The result is a regime*

with low legitimacy and low conflict, sustained by surveillance and fragmentation rather than belief.

This is a new equilibrium, one that earlier theory did not anticipate. The classical theory of legitimacy assumed that a regime must either earn compliance through belief or extract it through force. Compliance by atomization is a third path: the regime neither earns nor extracts compliance; it prevents the conditions under which compliance could be withheld.

The regime does not need to be believed. It needs only to be unopposable. And it is unopposable not because it is strong, but because the population cannot coordinate against it.

4 The Stability of the Equilibrium

Proposition 4.1 (The Stability of Atomization)**.** *The atomized equilibrium is stable in the sense that it reproduces itself. Fragmentation produces more fragmentation; surveillance produces more surveillance; the atomized individual produces more atomization. The equilibrium is self-reinforcing.*

The stability is real. The atomized individual does not organize, and the absence of organization confirms the atomization. The regime does not need to act, because the population has already been divided. The equilibrium is stable because it is self-reproducing.

But the stability is thin. The equilibrium depends on the continued operation of the atomization mechanism. When the mechanism fails—when a shock comes—the stored grievance releases suddenly.

Corollary 4.1 (The Thinness of the Equilibrium)**.** *The atomized equilibrium is stable but thin. Its stability depends on the continued capacity of the atomization mechanism to prevent the aggregation of grievance. When that capacity fails, the collapse is sudden and unexpected.*

5 The Sudden Collapse

The atomized equilibrium is vulnerable to shocks. A fiscal crisis, a legitimacy event, a new technology that defeats surveillance—any of these can break the atomization mechanism and release the stored grievance.

The collapse is sudden because the grievance has been accumulating invisibly. The regime mistakes the silence for consent. It sees no protests, so it assumes all is well. In reality, pressure is building. When the shock comes, the pressure releases all at once, and the collapse is unexpected.

This is why the present feels simultaneously stable and unstable. Both are true. The stability is structural; the instability is structural too. They coexist, and the balance between them depends on parameters that are themselves political.

6 The Correction

The correction to compliance by atomization is the re-aggregation of grievance. This requires the reconstruction of the conditions under which grievance can organize.

First, rebuild the commons. The common newspaper, the common space, the common institution—these are the infrastructure of collective action. They must be rebuilt, or their digital equivalents must be created.

Second, re-individualize the collective. The worker who is told that their exploitation is their own failure must be shown that it is a class-wide condition. The re-individualization of grievance is the precondition of its re-aggregation.

Third, defeat the surveillance. The surveillance of organization must be defeated, or the organization will be suppressed. This requires encryption, anonymity, and the construction of spaces that the platform cannot see.

Fourth, rebuild the "we." The deepest correction is the reconstruction of the collective self. The "we" that is the precondition of collective action must be rebuilt, one relationship at a time.

7 Conclusion

In every previous era, grievance could organize. Today, grievance is atomized. The algorithms that curate our attention fragment us into micro-publics that cannot coordinate. We are more informed than any previous generation, and less capable of acting together than any previous generation.

This is not a conspiracy. It is a structural feature of the new organization. The platforms that connect us also divide us, because division is more profitable than solidarity.

The result is an order that is stable not because it is just, but because grievance cannot aggregate. The framework calls this compliance by atomization: a regime with low legitimacy and low conflict, sustained by surveillance and fragmentation rather than belief.

It is a new equilibrium, one that earlier theory did not anticipate. Its stability is real but thin. When a shock comes—a fiscal crisis, a legitimacy event, a new technology that defeats surveillance—the stored grievance releases suddenly, and the collapse is unexpected.

This is why the present feels simultaneously stable and unstable. Both are true. The stability is structural; the instability is structural too. They coexist, and the balance between them depends on parameters that are themselves political.

The question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom? For the atomized order, the answer is: the platform's, and at the user's expense. The correction is to rebuild the "we" that the atomization has dissolved.

The rest is history—or its absence.